Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on William Butler Yeats's "To a Young Beauty"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's advice to his fellow-artist in "To a Young Beauty" include

allusion,
apostrophe,
caesura,
euphemism,
iambic tetrameter,
iambic trimeter,
masculine rhyme,
metaphor,
nursery rhyme,
personification,
rhetorical question,
rhyme scheme,
simile,
synecdoche,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant should focus on the differences that are associated with lines 4 and 5, in which the "best" is contrasted with the "rest," and also with the differences that are associated with the contrast between Beauvarlet's cherubim and Ezekiel's cherubim (lines 10-12), the footnotes' having pointed out that Ezekiel's cherubim—in the context of the poem's, which is the speaker's advice—represent the best (line 4) and Beauvarlet's the rest (line 5).

The contestant might focus on the implicit contrast between beauty (line 13) and age ("winters gone"; line 15), which is easily read as experience. The speaker's expectation of—"And I may dine at journey's end" (line 17)—the same critical acceptance earned by Walter Savage Landor and John Donne, as referenced in the last stanza (explained in the footnote), follows the speaker's advice to the young beauty/fellow-artist that he offers in the first two stanzas.